

“Whether ‘tis Nobler in the mind to suffer the slings of outrageous fortune, or to take arms against a sea of troubles, and by opposing end them.” (iii.i.57-58) Shakespeare’s *Hamlet* is considered by many to be the pinnacle of Jacobean theatre and has become the most written of work in the cannon. Complexity woven into the play allows Shakespeare to engage with and discuss the full capacity of human experience. Themes of oppression, corruption, love, loss, death, and family find ground within, and have the performance become an intimate experience of life. Reading the play aesthetically, generically, and thematically, as well as with feminist and psychoanalytical lenses, *Hamlet* becomes innately entwined with death. Ultimately, *Hamlet* is a constant exploration of what it means to die, most thoroughly realised through Hamlet’s *To Be or Not to Be* soliloquy.

Shakespeare writes both Ophelia and Gertrude to find liberation in their choice to take their own lives, describing the only real escape from oppression is death. As female characters, Gertrude and Ophelia are wholly under the control of dominant male characters and the only agency either holds in their own life is actively choosing and committing suicide, resonating with Hamlet’s remarks in his soliloquy. Gertrude describes Ophelia’s drowning, “she chanted snatches of old lauds as one incapable of her own distress, or like a creature native and indued to that element,” (iv.vii.178-180) as to convey that Ophelia entered willingly into dying. Gertrude’s own death is a powerfully defiant moment, where Claudius demands she doesn’t drink, “I will my Lord, I pray you pardon me.” (v.ii.269) Both female characters, under total constraint by the role their gender has been prescribed, actively decide to take their own lives to escape the oppression from dominant male figures in their lives. The state of their oppression is punctuated in Ophelia’s submission to Polonius, “I shall obey, my lord.” (i.iii.136) Their oppression under a patriarchal structure engages with what Hamlet refers to as “the slings and arrows of outrageous fortune,” “a sea of troubles,” and more blatantly, “th’oppressor’s wrong,” in his soliloquy (iii.i). Hamlet admits “by a sleep to say we end the heartache and the thousand natural shocks that flesh is heir to.” Ophelia and Gertrude are able to arrive at “the native hue of resolution,” in recognising they are able to escape the oppression they have been born into as women; they are liberated by their suicide. Hamlet’s soliloquy from a feminist perspective examines the faucet of death as liberation from hardship and suffering in life.

Recognising Hamlet as a modern hero in a Jacobean tragedy sees him plagued with emotional suffering and pondering death as it befalls those around him. Conventions of Jacobean tragedy demands the death of Hamlet’s father and seeking retribution by the murder of Claudius, but Hamlet is instead caught in the theological and philosophical dilemma of what dying encompasses. The ghost of old Hamlet demands, “if thou didst ever thy dear father love [...] revenge his foul and most unnatural murder.” (i.v.23-25) The Jacobean conventions of the ghost inspiring the protagonist to become vindictive present themselves so conspicuously as to call attention to how such conventions will eventually be subverted. Hamlet initially hopes to “sweep to [his] revenge” (i.v.31) with haste, as would conform to Jacobean tragedy. Hamlet is instead drawn to hesitation and pondering, acting against the archetype of vengeful protagonist. By exaggerating the exposition of Jacobean tragedy, Shakespeare is able to posit a model for the modern hero, who is caught in philosophical and logical entertaining rather than exclusively concerned with revenge. This model is exemplified in Hamlet’s soliloquy, where he examines the dilemma of choosing action or totally depriving the self of any action, “to be or not to be.” Shakespeare’s most poignant revelation through Hamlet as a modern hero defines, “conscience does make cowards of us all,” (iii.i.83) placing a keystone for the modern hero as someone caught upon their conscience, and their internal conflict, rather than external and active conflict, typical of Jacobean theatre. Where the soliloquy of iii.i defines Hamlet as a new kind of hero, the content of his introspection holds intense magnitude. Hamlet comes to understand the lack of knowing what death holds inspires a fear that overpowers the desire to escape the greatest hardship of living; “To sleep, perchance to dream. Ay, there’s the rub.” (iii.i.65) Hamlet’s pondering of

the philosophical leads to his total immobilisation, which is also significant within a psychoanalytical examination of the play.

The psychoanalytical colouring within *Hamlet* has Hamlet's super-ego paralyse him, entirely consumed with the hypothetical aspect of what death offers, which finds expression in his soliloquy. Under Freud's theory of the unconscious, Hamlet's super-ego has his contemplation of death consume his id, or his motivation to act, conveying how powerful death is as an abstract concept. Freud's model describes the ego acts as a mediator between the superego and the id; between ethics and philosophy, and primitive drive to action. We see Hamlet immobilised where he is given the opportunity to kill Claudius, "and now I'll do't – and so a goes to heaven," (iii.iii.74) he considers the action he is about to perform, "why, this is hire and salary, not revenge," (iii.iii.79) and he arrives at his conclusion, "no." (iii.iii.87) Hamlet reserves himself from bringing Old Hamlet's wishes to realisation because his superego overwhelmed his id to such a point the ego was unable to call him to action and resolve the play. Freud posits the ego is capable of mediating the unconscious to bring about synergy from pure thought, and instinctual action. Hamlet's superego is magnified, however, neatly summarised through the personification, "conscience does make cowards of us all," (iii.i.83) rendering Hamlet incapable of overcoming his theorising. Hamlet does not use conscience to refer to the discernment between right and wrong here, but instead to the content of his soliloquy. His soliloquy grapples with the constituents of dying; of leaving a mortal life and vacating to "the undiscovered country from whose bourn no traveller returns," seeing his cowardice not a shying away from his duty, but rather a restriction from acting in any capacity. By Freud's model, Shakespeare establishes Hamlet's processing of the abstract concept of death can consume any other function of the unconscious. We see that as Hamlet approaches a greater understanding of death, he is incrementally retarded. The psychoanalytical reading of Hamlet details that death as a concept is incomprehensible in its entirety.

Receiving the play aesthetically leads to being overwhelmingly plunged into existentialism and emerging with a more comprehensive personal understanding of the point of living. Hamlet's entire soliloquy in iii.i pivots about the point that we are unsure what lies beyond dying, throwing the audience into why they consider life worth suffering through. Arguing against living, advocating "not to be," Hamlet denotes, "the slings and arrows of outrageous fortune," "the heart-ache and the thousand natural shocks that flesh is heir to," "the whips and scorns of time, th'oppressor's wrong, the proud man's contumely, the pangs of disprized love, the law's delay, the insolence of office and the spurns that patient merit of th'unworthy takes." He solidifies reason for giving up on life and leaving behind such an expanse of suffering that threatens people in all conditions of life, likely, also, to have been inflicted upon viewers of the play. Hamlet considers the counter-argument and articulates the conflict emerging in the viewer, establishing that it is the "dread of something after death [...] puzzles the will, and makes us rather bear those ills we have than fly to others that we know not of." The soliloquy is a powerful submission to fear of the unknown. Hamlet considers it more worth living with the murder of his own father by his uncle, now married to his mother, cumulative with the other suffering he recognises having befallen others, than to hazard his being to whatever the afterlife holds, if anything at all. Hamlet is bound by the play to move his thoughts from the concept, but the audience is challenged by the conundrum; what is the point of living through such suffering? In place of the bleak resolution to the tragedy of most of the characters dying regardless of Hamlet's conclusion on the matter, the fear of the unknown can offer a hopeful arrival on the concept. It is not known what lies beyond death, but this presents us with the challenge of making the most of life while it is within our grasp. If our lives are the only form of existence we have, it promotes experiencing all the greatest and most fulfilling aspects of being alive; of being human. Hamlet's ultimatum of "to be or not to be," promotes a commitment of

'being' to its fullest through positive life experiences, when death becomes a finish line that may not offer anything after.

Shakespeare's *Hamlet* is an innately human experience, where Hamlet's comprehension of the conflict he faces draws out a personal response from the audience, and challenges them to consider what death means to them. Hamlet's *To Be or Not to Be* soliloquy conforms to and subverts generic convention, and is enhanced by the lenses of feminism, aesthetics, and psychoanalysis, allowing it to epitomise the full complexity of Shakespeare's work. This intimate exploration of death validates why the work continues to be criticised through all of literary history, and it continues to resonate with the human conceptualisation of death.